

Traveling the Atlas

THE CURATED COLLECTION

# Seven Hidden Gems *Worth Flying For*

*Destinations most travelers never find, and how to experience them well.*

CURATED BY KRYSTAL WINCHEL | TRAVELING THE ATLAS



A NOTE BEFORE YOU GO

# The best places rarely make the *obvious lists.*

The most memorable travel I've ever done wasn't at the landmark everyone photographs.

It was the quiet cove reached only by boat, the family-run table with no sign out front, the mountain village where the morning light did something I still think about years later.

My own travels through Peru, the Yucatán, Saint Lucia and Panama taught me that the difference between a good trip and an unforgettable one is almost never the destination on the brochure. It's knowing where to look, when to go and who to know once you arrive.

This is a short collection of seven places I love and can't stop recommending, each one a reward for the traveler willing to go a little further. Some are remote. Some are hiding in plain sight near places you already know. All of them are worth the flight.

Consider this an invitation. If one of them lights you up, that's exactly the conversation I love to have.

*Your travel advisor,*

*Krystal*

01

PERU

13.30° S 72.12° W

PERU

## The Sacred Valley, Beyond Machu Picchu

Everyone rushes to the citadel and leaves. The travelers who linger in the valley below, where Ollantaytambo's living Inca streets, the salt terraces of Maras and weaving villages carry on a craft unchanged in centuries, find the Peru that made me fall in love with this work.

**WHEN TO GO**

May to September, the dry season, with clear Andean skies.

**KRYSTAL'S TIP**

Spend your first nights in the valley instead of Cusco. It sits lower, which makes adjusting to the altitude far easier.

BEST FOR Culture seekers who want depth over checklists.

02

MEXICO

20.69° N 88.20° W

MEXICO

## The Quiet Coast of Yucatán

Skip the crowded strip. Inland cenotes glow an impossible blue, colonial towns like Valladolid serve some of the best food in the country, and small coastal pockets offer the warmth of the region without the noise. A place that rewards slowing down.

**WHEN TO GO**

November to April, when the days are drier and cooler.

**KRYSTAL'S TIP**

Reach the cenotes first thing in the morning. You'll often have the water to yourselves before the tour buses arrive.

BEST FOR Couples wanting beauty and calm in equal measure.

03

CARIBBEAN

13.86° N 61.06° W

CARIBBEAN

## Saint Lucia's Southern Reaches

Most visitors never leave the north. The south, in the shadow of the Pitons, holds volcanic beaches, rainforest that opens to the sea and boutique hideaways where the mountains meet the water. Dramatic, romantic and gloriously uncrowded.

**WHEN TO GO**

December to April, the island's dry season.

**KRYSTAL'S TIP**

Ask for a room facing the Pitons. It's the view you'll still be talking about years from now.

BEST FOR Honeymoons and anniversaries with a sense of drama.

04

CENTRAL AMERICA

9.57° N 78.82° W

CENTRAL AMERICA

## Panama's Wild Islands

Beyond the canal lies an archipelago of islands where the water is impossibly clear and the pace belongs to another era. Reachable, remote and utterly unspoiled. Proof that a bucket-list escape doesn't have to mean the far side of the world.

**WHEN TO GO**

Mid-December to April, the dry season.

**KRYSTAL'S TIP**

Pair the islands with a night or two in Panama City's historic Casco Viejo for the best of both worlds.

BEST FOR Adventurers craving true off-grid beauty.

05

PORTUGAL

41.19° N 7.55° W

PORTUGAL

## The Overlooked Douro Valley

Terraced vineyards fold down to a river that has carried wine for centuries. Small quintas welcome you like family, the tables are extraordinary, and a slow cruise upriver may be the most quietly luxurious thing you'll ever do.

**WHEN TO GO**

Late September into October for the harvest, or May and June for green hillsides.

**KRYSTAL'S TIP**

Arrive by train from Porto. The line hugs the river, and the views start before you even check in.

BEST FOR Food and wine travelers who value the unhurried.

06

CENTRAL EUROPE

46.36° N 14.09° E

CENTRAL EUROPE

## Slovenia's Julian Alps

A fairy-tale lake, an island church, emerald rivers and alpine trails, all without the crowds of its famous neighbors. Europe's best-kept secret for travelers who want mountains, storybook scenery and room to breathe.

**WHEN TO GO**

June to September, with September bringing fewer crowds.

**KRYSTAL'S TIP**

Lake Bled is the postcard. Nearby Lake Bohinj is the quiet one, and it's where I'd spend your afternoons.

BEST FOR Active couples who want mountains without the crowds.

07

MEXICO

17.07° N 96.73° W

MEXICO

# The Highlands of Oaxaca

A world away from the coast, this is Mexico's cultural heart, where mezcal is made by hand, textiles are dyed the old way and the food is revered by chefs worldwide. Deeply authentic, endlessly rewarding and still refreshingly under the radar.

**WHEN TO GO**

October to April, the dry season. Late October and early November bring Día de Muertos.

**KRYSTAL'S TIP**

If Día de Muertos is on your list, plan early. The best stays fill up many months ahead.

BEST FOR Immersive travelers who collect experiences, not selfies.

WHEN YOU BOOK THROUGH ME

## A little extra, at no extra cost.

As a Virtuoso affiliate, I can often add perks you won't find booking on your own, like room upgrades when available, daily breakfast, resort or spa credits and VIP recognition at many of the world's finest hotels. Amenities vary by property and are confirmed at booking.

YOUR NEXT CHAPTER

# Let's find the one that's *calling to you.*

These seven are only the beginning. When you're ready to turn inspiration into a beautifully planned trip, with every detail handled and every hidden door opened, I'd love to design it with you.


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TELL ME YOUR SOMEDAY

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